

ON TECHNIQUE

Polystylism

Although other composers, notably Charles Ives and Luciano Berio, had adopted similar techniques of quotation, allusion, and juxtaposition of different musical styles, it was Schnittke who explicitly used the term “polystylism” to describe his music, and it became a trademark of almost all his work from the mid-1960s until around 1985. This extrovert, brash, and sometimes chaotic presentation, combining and contrasting various styles ranging from Gregorian chant to electronic experimentalism, and incorporating both classical and popular idioms, chimed with the contemporary postmodernist movement, especially in its blurring of the distinction between high and low culture, and the fragmentation and collage of disparate ideas.

Alfred Schnittke was born in Engels, a port in the autonomous Volga-German Republic of the Soviet Union, a region that retained the culture and language of its original German émigré settlers. His father was a German Jew who had moved to Engels for work, and his mother a Volga German with a Catholic background, but both had embraced communism and Alfred had a secular upbringing.

From an early age, Schnittke had a sense of being an outsider, culturally different from the country he was born into. When his father was posted to Vienna in 1945, he immediately felt at home. He fell in love with Viennese culture, and especially the music of composers such as Mozart and Schubert rather than the 19th-century Russian nationalist composers who were revered in the